

SAME STROKES FOR DIFFERENT FOLKS: LESSONS FOR THE LED IN NIGERIAN DRAMA

by

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Abstract

The entire Nigerian economy is replete with unimaginable heights of economic hardships, free fall of the naira, galloping inflation, communal clashes, and banditry, near or lack of basic amenities among many others. This malaise cuts across ethnic, cultural, social and political boundaries of the six geo political zones. Therefore, the study takes its foothold on the Social Contract and Economic Vulnerability Theories, as it adopts a critical analysis and deductive leaning on some select Nigerian plays, with the view to correcting some erroneous primordial impressions that the Nigerian developmental retardation is ethnicity. Findings have it that one of the main problems of Nigeria stems from leadership flaws, as the leadership deliberately pitches it tent against the masses, making them vulnerable to impoverishment at any slightest opportunity. To achieve this, they manipulate their minds using religious and cultural platforms as baits to set them against themselves. This treatise therefore, recommends among others, the need for Non-Governmental Organizations to intensify more on the ongoing sensitization campaign on political and cultural orientations at the grass root. This understanding will hopefully go a long way to repositioning her economy for the overall wellbeing of the citizenry, as this study will create a platform for further academic references.

Keywords: *Drama, Ethnicity, Folks, Lesson, Nigeria.*

Introduction

The specter of ethnic domination, a legacy of colonialism, continues to loom large over Nigeria, exacerbating tensions and undermining national unity. The fear of being marginalized or dominated by other ethnic groups has become a recurring theme, with minority groups seeking recognition, protection, and equitable distribution of resources. This sentiment is most times fueled by politico-economic concerns about power sharing, resource allocation, and representation, leaving many Nigerians wondering who benefits from the country's resources and who controls the narrative. The fallout from this manipulation of its ethnic diversity by politicians to their advantage is why Majeed aptly notes "Nigeria has never been more divided, with fault lines deepening and agitations from various segments of society" (Majeed in Achor

Friday Akowe and Samson Idakwo 27). To overcome these challenges, Dennis Teghtegh warns that; Nigeria must adopt a more inclusive and aggregated approach to national development, where every individual and group contribute their unique strengths and perspectives (16).

This warning is apt because historically speaking hitherto Nigeria comprised various independent city-states, including the Oyo Empire, Benin Kingdom, Bornu Empire, and Sokoto Caliphate, each with distinct cultural values, affiliations, and systems of governance (Achor Friday Akowe and Samson Idakwo 26), and these diverse backgrounds have contributed to the country's intricate social fabric being that the current state of Nigeria is unsurprising, given the historical context of its formation. This argument is further accentuated by Aondowase Boh and Joseph Terkimbi Adoka positing that Nigeria being one of the largest black nations globally, richly endowed with human and natural resources and with its amalgamation over a century ago, has resulted in a complex entity characterized by diverse ethnicities, politics, economies, religions, and cultures, this diversity has led to numerous challenges that threaten its national unity (54). Pendants of Rhythm, corroborates Boh and Adoka that; this complexity of Nigeria's pluralistic society, with over 200 ethnic nationalities and significant religious differences, creates an environment prone to friction and crises (339).

A forced amalgamation of diverse entities without their consent should ordinarily create a relational vacuum, fostering an environment of tension and conflict. Consequently, Nigeria is gripped by escalating violence, threatening the peaceful coexistence of its people (Achor Friday Akowe and Mohammed-Kabir Imam 57). This situation in certain quarter is exacerbated by the chauvinistic tendencies of certain ethnic groups, which seek to impose their dominance beyond their traditional territories, thereby orchestrating these ethnic conflicts that leave the nation in a state of turmoil (Achor Friday Akowe and Samson Idakwo 27). This state of turmoil would have been better imagined than experienced because Nigerians now live with the legacy of this violence leaving behind (each time it occurs) a trail of devastation, including war casualties, wounded communities, and a proliferation of destitute and refugee populations, underscoring the urgent need for a more harmonious and inclusive national framework (Olu Obafemi 4). Therefore, suffice to say that; by fostering a sense of shared citizenship and promoting intercultural understanding, Nigeria can harness its diversity to drive growth, stability, and progress. Fortunately, many other nations with similar multifaceted backgrounds have demonstrated that this is possible, leveraging their diversities to build robust economies and harmonious societies.

The question then is: Is ethnicity the fundamental problem of Nigeria, if no why, then, does Nigeria struggle to replicate the success of other nations (contemporaries) in harnessing its diversity? This question is what this scholarship attempts to answer, because a dominant strand of Nigerian political scholarship identifies leadership failure and political manipulation as the most persistent obstacles to national development. According to this class of thought, since independence in 1960, Nigeria's political trajectory has been characterized by weak governance structures, elite domination, corruption, and the manipulation of democratic institutions for private gain. They argue that Nigeria's crisis is not primarily due to lack of resources, population pressure, or cultural limitations, but rather the failure of political leadership to transform state power into collective welfare. Additionally, they aver that leadership failure manifests through corruption, policy inconsistency, institutional decay, and political exclusion, while political

manipulation operates through electoral malpractice, ethnic mobilization, patronage networks, and elite capture. Together, these dynamics have produced what many analysts describe as a postcolonial governance paradox a resource-rich state trapped in chronic underdevelopment (Achebe 1, Ake 6, Joseph 8 and, Ekeh 107). For instance, according to Chinua Achebe, Nigeria's fundamental problem is "simply and squarely a failure of leadership," emphasizing that corruption and institutional collapse stem from leaders unwilling to model accountability and ethical governance (Achebe 1).

The scholarly consensus above strongly positions leadership failure and political manipulation as central explanations for Nigeria's persistent developmental challenges. Nigerian scholarship consistently demonstrates that the crisis of governance lies less in resource scarcity than in how political power is acquired, exercised, and sustained. However, while many scholars foreground leadership failure, some caution against reducing Nigeria's problems solely to bad leaders. Structural factors such as colonial economic dependency, global capitalism, and socio-economic inequality also shape governance outcomes. Therefore, it is the position of this erudition that the answer from the question asked above will definitely go a long way to ameliorate the plights of the commoners (led) and also create a space/threshold for/into further academic engagements.

A matter as serious as this will naturally attract the goodwill of well-meaning Nigerians to lend out a voice to other gamut of literatures from the past and 'present past' in order to look for the way out this quagmire. The humanities, with their focus on humanizing and amplifying human concerns, hold some answers. Through creative and graphic endeavours, the humanities can spark critical thinking, provoke dialogue, and inspire collective action. Drama, in particular, has the power to transform individuals and communities by presenting complex issues in a way that resonates with audiences. By stimulating critical reflection and decision-making, drama can bring about attitudinal shifts and inspire proactive solutions to societal problems. This reality Achor Akowe and Chidiebere Ekwereiri substantiate that:

...the dramatic enterprise is not exempted from the culture of evenly trying to recreate human social relationship after its genre. Dramatists therefore, within the artistic space, capture the social-political interrogations of their everyday realities. This they do by creating imaginative characters and dialogue from the human social transaction that plays out on regular bases in order to make concrete statement; either to applaud credible landmark(s)/feats and/or to condemn certain societal ills that clog the wheel of progress of the society. (135)

From the foregoing, drama is a platform for social commentary and critique, as it helps communities re-examine their values and norms, and work towards creating a more just and equitable society. This goal is crucial, considering the devastating consequences of political manipulation of ethno-religious clashes, which result in loss of lives, destruction of properties, and massive economic losses. Nigeria cannot afford to lag behind in citizens' welfare and scientific advancement. The country's leaders have long grappled with ensuring national unity, as "since independence in 1960, the nation's leader until now has grappled with the challenge of ensuring the Nigeria nation remains undivided" (Adukwu Martins Adukwu 340). The division along ethno-religious and political lines poses a significant problem to nation-building, fueling national debates. However, it's essential to recognize that these crises often have underlying

political motivations. The masses, who typically coexist peacefully, are frequently manipulated by selfish political interests that exploit ethnicity and religion to further their agendas. It's high time the led (masses) became aware of this ploy and recognized their shared interests in fighting against exploitation and oppression. By understanding their collective disadvantage, they can unite to demand their rights and challenge the status quo.

Methodology

To achieve the feat above, the study by way of qualitative methodology, will critically analyze the two texts under study with consultation of other online and offline scholarly materials, and also grounding it foothold on Social Contract Theory and Economic Vulnerability Theory to deductively infer meanings that, most of the ethnic clashes in Nigeria is a highjack of the masses' political sensibility by political gladiator's for selfish gains.

Theoretical Framework

Social Contract Theory Social Contract Theory is one of the most influential political and philosophical frameworks used to explain the origin of society, governance, law, morality, and citizens' obligations to the state. The theory proposes that human beings voluntarily agree either explicitly or implicitly to surrender some freedoms in exchange for social order, protection, and collective security. Rather than political authority arising from divine right or natural hierarchy, Social Contract Theory argues that legitimate government derives from the consent of the governed.

The roots of Social Contract Theory can be traced to classical philosophical reflections on justice and political order. However, the theory reached systematic formulation during the European Enlightenment (17th–18th centuries), a period marked by rational inquiry, scientific progress, and resistance to absolute monarchy. The major Proponents of Social Contract Theory are: Thomas Hobbes (1588–1679), John Locke (1632–1704) and Jean-Jacques Rousseau (1712–1778), and the central question addressed by these social contract theorists is: Why should individuals obey political authority? Their answer to the question is that individuals consent to political organization because life without social agreement would be insecure or chaotic.

To Hobbes human beings are naturally self-interested and driven by fear, competition, and desire for power. In the hypothetical state of nature, a condition without government life would be: “solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short” (Hobbes 89). To escape this state, Laskar, quoted in Louis Lawrence, noted that people entered into two agreements: 'pactum unionis' and 'pactum subjectionis'. The first pact ensured security of lives and property, while the second pact established allegiance to a central authority in exchange for protection. This agreement legitimized the government's authority and imposed a moral responsibility to protect citizens' interests. However, when governments fail to deliver security and welfare, citizens can withdraw their support. Locke and Rousseau argue that citizens have the right to hold their government accountable, and if necessary, replace it. The state, distinct from the government, exists to dispense justice and protect citizens' rights. (283).

To Locke, in the state of nature, individuals possess natural rights: Life; Liberty and Property. By implication, Government exists not to dominate citizens but to protect these rights. Political

authority therefore depends on popular consent. Therefore, if rulers violate citizens' rights, people have the legitimate right to resist or replace the government.

In a nut shell, Social Contract Theory provides a foundational explanation for the emergence of political authority and organized society. Through the contributions of Hobbes, Locke and Rousseau, the theory evolved from advocacy of absolute sovereignty to modern democratic ideals grounded in consent, rights, and collective participation. Its enduring relevance lies in its ability to explain the reciprocal relationship between citizens and the state, an agreement balancing freedom with social responsibility.

Economic Vulnerability Theory

Economic Vulnerability Theory explains how individuals, households, communities, or nations become exposed to economic risks due to limited resources, structural inequalities, unstable income systems, and weak coping mechanisms. The theory examines why certain groups suffer more severely from poverty, economic shocks, unemployment, health crises, and social exclusion than others. The roots of Economic Vulnerability Theory can be traced to development economics, poverty studies, and social risk analysis of the late twentieth century. Scholars like; Amartya Sen, Joseph Stiglitz, Douglass North, Alberth Hirschman, Robert Chambers, Stephen Devereux, Rachel Saates-Wheeler among other proponents of this theory have contributed to the evolution of economic vulnerability theory, providing valuable insights into understanding and addressing economic vulnerability (Martha Fineman par 2).

One of the earliest contributors, Robert Chambers (1989), conceptualized vulnerability as a condition characterized by defenselessness, insecurity, and exposure to risk among marginalized populations. Chambers distinguished poverty from vulnerability by emphasizing uncertainty and the inability to cope with shocks (Chambers 1-3).

Economic vulnerability is not merely the presence of poverty; rather, it refers to the risk of falling into poverty or deeper deprivation when exposed to economic stressors such as inflation, illness, unemployment, or policy changes. Scholars argue that vulnerability results from the interaction between economic structures and social conditions (Chambers 1). Chambers is widely credited with formalizing vulnerability within development discourse. He identified two major components: External exposure to risks and Internal lack of coping capacity. He argued that poor populations are vulnerable because they lack buffers such as savings, social protection, and institutional support (Chambers 2).

Later, Amartya Sen (1999) expanded the discussion through the Capability Approach, arguing that vulnerability occurs when individuals lack the economic and social capabilities needed to live meaningful lives. According to Sen, deprivation results not only from low income but also from restricted access to education, healthcare, and opportunities (Sen 87). Sen's Capability Approach strengthened Economic Vulnerability Theory by linking economic insecurity to human freedom. He emphasized that vulnerability emerges when individuals cannot convert resources into well-being outcomes due to structural barriers (Sen 75). Similarly, Caroline Moser (1998) introduced the Asset Vulnerability Framework, explaining that households become economically vulnerable when their asset base-human, financial, social, and physical capital is weak. The fewer assets individuals possess, the less resilient they are during economic

crises (Moser 3). These scholars expanded the theory to national economies, particularly developing countries. They argued that economic vulnerability includes: dependence on limited export commodities, exposure to global market shocks and weak institutional capacity. Their work connected vulnerability to globalization and economic instability (Naudé et al. 5).

In summary, the core assumptions of Economic Vulnerability Theory rests on several fundamental assumptions like: Economic inequality produces unequal exposure to risk; Limited assets increase susceptibility to poverty; External shocks disproportionately affect marginalized populations; Social structures such as gender, education, and health status influence vulnerability; Resilience depends on access to resources, institutions, and social networks. Thus, vulnerability is understood as a dynamic condition rather than a fixed state.

The choice of these theories are predicated on their relevance to this study as the social contract theory clearly explain that the style of governance in this country is such that the citizens of Nigeria have entered into a social contract with the Nigerian government surrendering their individual rights to their political leaders in order to secure their well fare and lives. Secondly, it spells out equally the repercussion of the breach of such contract. While the economic vulnerability theory, among others of its tenets emphasis the place of how a government could deliberately make policy or take actions that can weaken the economic potentials of the citizenry and resultantly rendering them vulnerable to political manipulations, it goes ahead to score the fact that such maltreatment could also trigger resilience in the oppressed. This position is what the next segment of this paper relays.

Synopses

The Masquerade Called Religion by Regina Ode relays the story of a community called Airegin, a community which members, even though with diverse religious, ethnic, cultural, social and political backgrounds, live in a relatively peaceful co-existence until its political class in desperation to grasp power by all means, extend their demonic and dubious political strategies beyond the purview of electoral regulations. This they did by taking advantage of the illiteracy and poverty status of the unsuspecting community members to instigate violence among them for their own selfish interest. But it was not long their game is uncovered, making the commoners to quickly pool themselves together to resist their further manipulation. Hence, there is a turn of the political table leading to the toppling of the political glass that has been making life miserable for them.

Zango-kataf Woman by Clifford Nwanna, equally, captures the reality of another community of Zango-Kataf, with similar socio-economic, religious, political and cultural backgrounds and who also live in a social peaceful co-existence until the civil war brakes up. Mr. and Mrs. Nwonye have to relocate to the East to avoid being killed by the Nigerian Army. This period coincides with when Mrs. Nwonye is to give birth to her premature baby. In the heat of the moment, they decide to leave the child behind with Mama James. The same grows and marries a police officer from the North their dialectical difference notwithstanding among others.

Textual Analysis

It would not be out place to say that most Nigerians are nostalgic as they bemoan the old good days where they once lived in a relatively cordial relationship among themselves despite their

cultural, religious, economic and social backgrounds. Nigerians dream of living freely in a fraternal society they could trust of living as one with themselves, living among and with others, they dream of living healthily, peacefully and dignified lives in a strong and prosperous country that could watch over them, but that seem to be a slippery dream in several areas because the present resurgent of hate simply cannot be ignored (Armstrong Matiu Adejoh 172). It is this desire or crave that the two plays under our spotlight reveal. They plainly capture how the community's members live happily regardless of their religious and ethnic bias. For instance in *The Masquerade*... a stage direction relays thus:

(It is in the morning and some traders are seen arranging their wares. Others are coming in from home. The atmosphere is very friendly; traders are seen greeting and interacting freely. It is noticeable that some are Christians while others are Muslims... (3)

In *Zango Kataf*...

(A labour room in a local maternity in a remote part of Zango- Kataf. A woman gives birth to a seven month old premature baby. The local midwife is seen with the baby surrounded by attendants, neighbours (mostly women.) Among them are Mama James and an Accouncheur... (43)

From the excerpts above, it clearly shows that Nigerians, even with their ethnic and religious backgrounds notwithstanding, may not necessarily have problems co habiting among themselves in whatever environment they find themselves. Even though Nigerian state is a botched political and administrative configuration, Nigerians in their low economic blotch and statue, have no business attacking each other, as their primary concern at the moment is how to make ends meet because of the situation where they find themselves. They have to labour too hard to escape the ever deepening quagmire of abject poverty even in the face of abundant natural and human resources. Even in their low esteem they do not only live for oneself, but one for another. For instance, in the labour room where Mrs. Nwonye is to give birth to her premature baby, she is not only surrounded by the midwife and hospital attendant, but also by neighbours in solidarity and in appreciation that they are a cluster, their differences notwithstanding. This study makes this assertion, reminding us that Zango-Kataf is in Kaduna State, located at the Central Northern region of Nigeria and Mrs. Nwonye is from Awka, the capital city of Anambra State, located at the Southern Eastern block of Nigeria. This scenario is important to this study, because what ordinarily occupies the mind of an average Nigerian is to engage extra hard in their vocations to be set free the economic and political emasculation perpetrated by the Nigerian political actors, who takes pleasure in seeing the masses suffer. At this point we can say that even though the depth of our ethnic frontline is gaining ascendancy, crises along ethnicity and religion could be a mastermind of some political leaders, and not necessarily with their differences.

To say the least, a situation whereby these commoners find themselves living in abject poverty even in the face of abundant natural and human resources, naturally brings them together into an alliance either consciously or unconsciously. Hence, they do not only live for oneself, but one for another in order to navigate safely through the land mine of bad governance. Be that as it may, it is also on a record that this marriage of convenience arranged by the colonial administrators is over hundred years, yet we are still here as a country, but that is not to say that there has not been attempts of some ethnic groups threatening to secede. It is also no news that at

the root of every threat is economic and political summersault orchestrated by the nation's leadership. For example:

In *The Masquerade...*

Mr Chairman: Ladies and Gentlemen of honour, I will not close my eyes to the reality in what chief Wale has pointed out. If something is not done and fast too, we will all be disgraced. I have a suggestion to put to this gathering. We all know that our opponent is highly supported by both Muslims and Christians. Since he came on the scene, we have seen unprecedented unity between the two religions; and you know like I do that they make up the greatest force that we have to contend with in this state. Ladies and gentlemen, in order to break the right arm of our common enemy, I submit that we divide this camp. It is said a house divided against itself cannot stand...we need both religious groups to be at each other's neck (11).

The foregoing dialogue thrusts the fore of the discourse of social contract theory which tenets agrees that the citizens willingly surrender their rights to the government so that their well fare is sustained. The concern here is, of what need does an opposing political party has to change a the government who has the support of the people? Here we see the Chairman addressing party members on the need to still upset the support balance the people have with the ruling party despites ethnic and religious. This non patriotic stance is why Claude Ake argues that African states, including Nigeria, operate as instruments of elite accumulation rather than vehicles of development. Political power becomes a means of economic extraction rather than public service, producing governance systems disconnected from citizens' needs (Ake 6). Leadership failure therefore transforms the state into a site of competition for resources rather than national planning. Additionally, the push by some political leaders to put the people apart so that they can perpetrate the corruption is why they have to instigate war, ethnic, religious and communal clashes. For example, In *Zango-Kataf...*

(Hostilities have started in the most part of Northern Nigeria, even in Zango-Kataf, Easterners are killed in large numbers. Mama Nwonye and her husband cannot run to Awka with a premature baby. They have to leave her behind with someone who can take care of her). (43)

From the study's earlier summation, Nigeria's leadership most often than not takes advantage of ethnicity and religion of their unsuspecting followers to sow a seed of hatred among members of their communities any time they failed in governance to see to the overall well beings of their people.. While in *Zango- Kataf...* the hostility that breaks up and leading to the killings of the Easterners is a re-enactment of the Nigerian Civil War triggered by two political actors, (General Yakubu Gowon Rtd. and Late Colonel Ojukwu Odumegwu, as alleged in some arguments,) who refused to shift grounds on an agreement that was reached. Many of the victim as of the time that war had no personal grouse with one another. That is why Mama Nwonye has to leave her premature baby under the safe care of Mama James the Zango-Kataf woman. Symbolically speaking, this act only tells us how united Nigerians can be without the political manipulations of the leaders.

Furthermore, the political class is aware that when once its gimmick is set in motion and the aforementioned peaceful balance is upset, members that have enjoyed cordial relationship

overtime are set against each other. The class equally know that when once the face off is triggered it will further aggravates the suffering of the people. The backlash is that precious lives are not only lost, valuables which they acquire through unimaginable toils and torture running into millions of naira are equally destroyed. Resultantly, this will naturally lead to the further deterioration of their miserable state, as the living are left struggling with unimaginable heights of economic hardships, severe hunger, free fall of the naira, galloping inflation, near or lack of basic amenities, job loss, joblessness among many others. This is what the economic vulnerability theory tries to buttress, because from the scenario painted so far, it is crystal clear that the Nigerian political class is just being wicked to the poor people as they deliberately ensure that the masses are exposed to some socio-economic hardship so that they can become economically vulnerable for manipulation while they loot the treasury. The duo captures this pitiable and miserable left over of the carnages of their manipulations on the masses thus:

In *The masquerade...*

AHMED: So between those men and women, they tactfully placed our otherwise peaceful environment on a ticking bomb just waiting to be detonated.

ADAH: Do you know that more than fifty people, including the poor akara girl lost their lives not to mention the loss of properties? ... (26)

MADAM: Hey. My sister, na God oh, if not dem they don kill me finish. Dem spoil everything wey de my shade, na only me commot from here go house, kurma see the wound wey I wound. (28)

In *Zango-Kataf...*

PAPA NWONYE: Mama Nwonye! Mama Nwonye! Don't make yourself a target! Take cover! (*Bombing now stops and everywhere is calm. The air is filled with thick smoke. Mama Nwonye is seen weeping over the body of her dear husband. Bodies litter the place. There is an atmosphere of grief...*). (56)

OKEKE: ...we lost our path while serving our country, this, you might not understand. But can we free our bodies and souls from shackles of politics and religion? We once acted like brethren, that was long before this politics came, indeed politics did come. And religion is still here. Man has ceased to be his own brother's keeper as it were in the beginning. Where is our hospitality that made us proud? Where is our bravery that made us heroes? Where is our wisdom that made us sage. we are now like veritable gourd cut equal by those forces. Those forces we know, forces pulling us apart...). (55-6)

From Papa Nwonye and Okeke's dialogue, Nigerian politicians cannot claim to be serving this nation by instigating tribal and religious sentiments when the primary concern of governance is to see to the protection of lives and property and the overall wellbeing of the ruled. Nigerian own style of governance to this study, is one that has made its people cannibals. It has succeeded in inculcating in the downtrodden, the culture of debauched neighbourliness. For this style of leadership, it does not matter what, how and for how long Nigerians should continue to suffer, it does not count how many souls and property should be and are lost. Some Nigerian politicians

are bent on ensuring that an average Nigerian does no longer care about what evil befalls a neighbour anymore. No wonder, as Akowe seems to be reechoing the conversation among **Ahmed, Adah** and **Madam** claiming “the nation has not known peace since independence as we have witnessed over time and still witnessing on daily basis on our political platform the wanton loss of innocent lives and destruction of valued properties occasioned by these several communal clashes, ethno-religious fracas... Achor Friday Akowe” (86). When we have this kind of dossier, it only becomes evident that, “many Nigerians would have been denied the basic needs of life, because the standard of living keeps hyping by day and day and for this reason, poverty net will continue to drag more Nigerians into gratuitous penury as the day goes by. (Achor Friday Akowe and Lucy Onaivi 271)

Therefore at this trajectory of learning, could it be right to say, it is because of the above that Nigeria has lost its heroism, hospitality in scheme of global affairs and which is why it is being treated with strict vista allowance, xenophobic attacks and the most recent; Nigerians are being asked to leave Ghana, a neighbouring country? Generally, if Nigeria is truly the giant of Africa, as it claims, it should be an economic hub, a tourist and hospital destinations to admiration of not only African countries but other continents of the world. The Nigerian leaders owe this country the task of taking this country to that enviable feat it is known for in the past, to make it great again to the desire of all. This crave is achievable if our leaders will shift focus from aggrandizement of public fund to the real tenets of governance which is people centred. Moreover, the bitter scenario graphically captured above, will naturally weaken the economic power of the masses, exposing them to some level or degree of economic risks, such as job loss, price increase, or income reduction which Fineman Martha mentioned above as one of the indicators of economic vulnerability tenets. But that is not to say all hope is gone, because the plays under scrutiny reiterate the social contract theory that emphasis the power and unity inherent diversity. This position is further validated consequently:

In the masquerades...

(The crowd is now quiet; all eyes are on Adah to hear his response. Adah lifts his head, looks at the faces surrounding him; he sighs like some who is aware of the task ahead).

ADAH: I will go for you.

(The crowd goes wild with dancing and celebration Christians and Muslims are seen hugging and shaking hands one with another. People all around congratulate Adah, Ahmed and one another... someone in the crowd raises a song and they all begin to sing). (36)

(The play moves back to the beginning and the celebration continues with much dancing and winning. The people are happy because for once, their will has prevailed). (39)

In Zango-Kataf...

MAMA JAMES: Wayee! (Mary goes to open the door to admit Mr. Bako,

Nwonye. Esther gets up to embrace her husband, Bako. Mama James is dumfounded and excited on seeing Mama Nwonye. Mama Nwonye runs to Mama James and embraces her, full of emotions. Nwonye and others look on).

MAMA JAMES: It is the will of God that we will meet again. (69)

“Ethnic diversity is an asset, not an omen. Nigeria's ethnic diversity works like the oral apparatus. The tongue and teeth may have conflicts, but they remain together to achieve the shared goal of chewing and digesting food. Nigeria's ethnic diversity is nature's gift to the nation. If properly managed, it becomes an asset, if poorly managed; it becomes an omen for disunity (Louis Lawrence in Ngare 282).” The isolated passages from the two scripts are a clear demonstration of pactum subjectionis in the social contract theory; where “the government has the moral responsibility to keep to their side of the bargain. Since subjects relinquished their rights to be led by a ruler, it is implied that they trust the ruler's discretion to make laws that will promote, not hurt, their common interests. However, when government fails in their duty to give subjects the expected benefits of having a government's security and welfare, citizens can withdraw support for the government. This is achievable because, state exists for the dispensation of justice and hence, the government can be over thrown (Laskar in Louis 283)”. For example, in *The Masquerade...* we see how the people quickly discover the tricks of their political actors and obviously formed their own political party, elected their own and eventually win the election. The same feat is recorded among the poor people in *Zango-Kataf...* as they refused ethnic and religious matrix put in place by their leaders to tear them apart. Hence, there is a reunion and a marriage among this people despite their ethnic differences. This then is a clear manifestation that even though Nigerian masses are of different folks they remain the same folks, folks under the strokes of mal-administrative yokes of bad leadership which they must all come together to demystify, because hunger, poverty, inflation, job loss, joblessness... does not know ethnic barriers. Therein lays the strength in their diversity.

Discussion

The discourse so far addresses the escalation of ethnic and communal clashes in Nigeria ever since independence. This is an ill wind that has no blown Nigeria any good. This menace has left many precious lives dead and the loss of valuable property running in millions (if not billions) of Naira. Report card as this can rob any of its developmental strides. These crises are usually dressed in either religious or ethnic colouration by the manipulation of the political class because of their selfish interests as espoused by the two texts under review. From the plays under review, it is crystal clear that the political class can go to the extent of stirring violence among peaceful loving Nigerians. The economic vulnerability theory, in one of its tenets, which is paramount to this study, is the making and implementing of policies by the leaders, which deliberately puts the masses under social and economic pressures rendering them vulnerable to manipulations. Also of importance to this study is the social contract theory that supports the surrendering of the governed's rights to the ruling power, so as to have their wellbeing protected, and where there is a breach of contract, the people have the right to refuse giving their mandate to such a government.

These theories find some of their tenets in the two play texts analyzed as the masses in the two texts that had lived relatively in peace soon found out to be at each other's neck. But they soon

found out the tricks of their leaders and voted them out of power as in the case of the *Masquerade*... and the marriage between the Hausa Police Officer, Bako and Esther of the Igbo family symbolizing oneness despite religious and ethnic differences. (*Zango-Kataf* 69-70)

Conclusion

Nigeria being one of the countries with the largest coloured race in the world is blessed with multi ethnic diversity, housing over 200 groups. This kind of configuration should ordinarily, provoke social friction among other from time to time, most especially when these various groups were coerced (by the colonial administrators for their selfish economic gains) to co-habit regardless of their diverse differences. This arrangement has not really gone down well with this country as over the past sixty-five years of self-independence it has recorded huge number of ethnic clashes which has continued to threaten the unity of its people. Findings from this appraisal so far clearly reveal that, most of the clashes are not entirely ethnical, as they have severe political undertones. Take for instance or consider how many times the northern Nigeria has produced democratic presidents and military heads of state compared to other geo political zones. The north has produced them many more times than any zone. Yet “the poverty rate in Northern Nigeria is extensively high, with the 2022 National Multidimensional Poverty Index Survey reporting that 65% of the population in the north is multidimensional poor which translates to 86 million people. This is substantially higher 35% poverty rate in the south and is reflected in several specific Northern states having poverty rate above 80% such as Sokoto (91%), Jigawa (83.3%), and Zamfara (82.7%). This accounts for 86 million poor individuals in the region out 133 million Poor in Nigeria (National Bureau of Statistics. <https://www.nigerianstat...>)”. Therefore, if Nigeria is on the global news stand breaking the record presently as the global headquarters of poverty, its northern states are the worst hit. Then this goes to prove the above claim, because these presidents and heads of state should have bettered ordinarily the lots of their people. The point being made here is that most times the political gladiators use ethnicity as a political gimmick to keep the unsuspecting masses at each other's throats (as a diversionary means) so as to perpetuate the looting of the national treasury. Going forward, when once the treasury is looted by individual politicians, the wellbeing of masses is relegated to the background, thereby making them economically vulnerable to their manipulations. But under the social contract mechanism, the masses need to wake up and realize that neither religion nor ethnicity is the problem. They should also know that by virtue of their predicament (same stroke), which is obvious in the gap between them and the political class, where they live in abject lack and want and they in affluence respectively), they have to come together (even though of different folks) to fight a common enemy that have refused them their welfare packages.

Armed with the investigation from this academic exercise, the study makes bold to recommend that Multi-International donors, Non-Governmental Organizations and Human Rights Activists interested in championing the course of the promotion of fundamental human rights of the defenseless, voiceless and depraved should do more to push their campaign frontiers to the grass roots where they could work with Community Based Organizations, Community Theatre Practitioners to enlighten the commonalities the more that; their class status is a formidable force that can change their narrative if only they will refuse to be hoodwinked by the political class regardless of their pains and shelve their differences for their overall wellbeing and that this study is not an end to, but threshold into further studies.

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